



Book Review: Language Education in Saudi Arabia: Integrating Technology in the Classroom

Hajar Khalifa Al Sultan

Department of English Language, College of Arts, King Faisal University, Al Ahsa, Saudi Arabia



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ABSTRACT

This review explores the contribution of Language Education in Saudi Arabia: Integrating Technology in the Classroom, edited by Al-Hoorie, Mitchell, and Elyas, emphasizing how its collected studies reflect current pedagogical practices while offering valuable directions for future research. Bringing together corpus analyses, case studies, systematic reviews, and practitioner reflections, the volume provides context-sensitive insights into technology-enhanced language education in Saudi Arabia, with a focus on tools such as ChatGPT, flipped learning, and virtual writing platforms. A unifying theme across the chapters is that technology's effectiveness depends on teacher support, critical reflection, and contextual awareness. While the editors frame the volume as addressing both teaching and learning, most chapters emphasize teacher experiences, classroom practices, and instructional tools. Learner voices, emotional responses, and motivational dynamics remain underexplored, especially in relation to digital tools and AI. Additionally, the empirical scope leans toward urban, English-dominant higher education contexts, with fewer insights from K–12, rural, or multilingual settings. Nonetheless, the volume offers a valuable foundation for educators and policymakers. Future research could build on this work by more deeply engaging with learner perspectives, exploring ethical dimensions of AI, and addressing the sociocultural diversity within Saudi educational contexts.

KEYWORDS

Language education, educational technology, vision 2030, Saudi Arabia, artificial intelligence (AI), learner-centered pedagogy

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1. Introduction

The edited volume *Language Education in Saudi Arabia: Integrating Technology in the Classroom* offers a timely and scholarly examination of Saudi Arabia's language education reform within the framework of Vision 2030. Featuring contributions from leading researchers and educators, the book explores the practical, empirical, and theoretical intersections of language pedagogy and technological innovation across Saudi educational settings. Emphasizing digital innovation, educational reform, and global competitiveness, Al-Hoorie, Mitchell, and Elyas contend that language education—particularly English—is central to equipping citizens with the skills essential for a knowledge-based economy. The volume is thus positioned as a response to this national priority, illustrating how technology is increasingly integrated into language teaching and learning across various educational levels and contexts within the Kingdom. The nine chapters, organized into four thematic clusters—learner corpora and data-driven learning (DDL), technological innovations, multimedia integration, and artificial intelligence (AI)—offer a comprehensive yet critical perspective on the evolving digital language education ecosystem in Saudi Arabia. This review summarizes each chapter and offers a critical analysis of its content. Key issues raised in the edited volume are then discussed, followed by an evaluation of the authors' central arguments. The analysis is grounded in evidence from the text and informed by current literature, identifying gaps in the treatment of key topics. Recommendations for future research and policy follow.

2. Summary of Chapters

In Chapter 1, titled, Learner Corpus Research and Data-Driven Learning (DDL), Eman Al Nafjan and Sabria Jawhar explore the current state of learner corpus research in Saudi Arabia. This chapter highlights how DDL methodologies—such as the Saudi Learner Corpus—have enabled data-informed insights into learner errors and

instructional materials. Despite sparse corpus compilations compared to global standards, the authors argue convincingly for corpus-based instruction to improve academic writing and pragmatic competence. Implications for the Saudi classroom include promoting teacher training in corpus tools and embedding DDL strategies into writing-intensive courses, particularly in EAP and ESP contexts.

While this chapter makes a commendable effort in promoting learner corpus research and DDL in Saudi language education, its focus on written corpora, though valuable, could be further enriched by acknowledging the potential of spoken and multimodal corpora. These additional modalities are essential for comprehensive language development and fostering learner engagement with authentic language use (Pérez-Paredes and Ordoñana-Guillamón, 2025). Rather than viewing the emphasis on written data as a shortcoming, it can be seen as a focused starting point that future studies might build upon. Expanding to include other corpus types could support varied learning goals and enable teachers to design listening tasks, conversation prompts, or pragmatic activities. The absence of discussion on corpus diversity—as outlined by Boulton (2017)—limits the chapter's pedagogical reach, particularly in contexts where learner autonomy is critical. Although the chapter touches on English textbooks and translation pedagogy, it could offer stronger connections between DDL and learner agency in under-resourced or exam-driven environments. Framing these areas as opportunities for future research would enhance the chapter's relevance and provide more actionable guidance for educators.

In Chapter 2, Basim Alamri and Assem Alqarni review ten corpus linguistic studies in Saudi Arabia, covering areas such as vocabulary, stance-taking, textbook analysis, and translation. They identify methodological inconsistencies and emphasize the need for institutional support to advance localized learner corpora and integrate corpus training into teacher education. This chapter adopts a broader analytical scope by highlighting underexplored areas such as spoken corpora, rhetorical functions, and genre comparisons

involving international students. Additionally, it advocates for expanding research to include graduate students, pre-service and in-service teachers, and faculty-populations less commonly addressed in corpus-based research in the region. While general corpora like COCA provide a foundational resource, the chapter argues that Saudi classrooms would benefit more from locally developed corpora that capture the linguistic realities and educational needs of students. By focusing on a wider range of research agendas and participant groups, Chapter 2 contributes a valuable perspective on how corpus linguistics can evolve within the Saudi context without directly mirroring the scope or focus of Chapter 1.

Chapter 3 presents an empirical, corpus-based study by Vijayakumar Chintalapalli and Navya Bahl on how novice Saudi EFL writers express their stance in academic writing. Using Hyland's stance model, the authors analyze 532 essays written by Preparatory Year Program (PYP) students, focusing on hedges, boosters, attitude markers, and self-mentions. The findings reveal an overuse of boosters and minimal use of self-mentions and attitude markers-indicating limited rhetorical awareness and learner engagement. The authors emphasize the need for writing instruction to move beyond formulaic structures and foster rhetorical flexibility. They argue that Saudi instructors should design workshops that teach stance variation and support learner agency in academic writing.

While the study offers valuable insights into stance-taking among Saudi EFL learners, it falls short of linking its findings to learner-centered pedagogy. The underuse of self-mention and attitude markers suggests a lack of learner confidence, voice, and autonomy-critical components of academic writing. Although the corpus effectively highlights writing patterns, its pedagogical potential remains underutilized. To bridge this gap, the study should have offered concrete strategies for integrating DDL into instruction. Engaging students in analyzing authentic texts, comparing stance features across genres, and co-constructing evaluation criteria would help them develop rhetorical awareness and ownership of their writing. Such an approach would connect corpus analysis to broader issues of identity, agency, and learner empowerment in academic discourse.

Chapters 4, 5, and 6 address a central theme of the volume: the integration of innovative technologies into language learning. In Chapter 4, Khoud Ghrzan presents a case study on the use of Microsoft's *Reading Progress* tool in Najran, Saudi Arabia, demonstrating its effectiveness in improving reading fluency, motivation, and learner autonomy among elementary students. Using a mixed-methods approach-including interviews, observations, and questionnaires-the study gathered data from 21 students and 34 English teachers. The results indicate that the tool positively impacted students' reading skills, self-confidence, listening and speaking abilities, and motivation to read. The *Reading Progress* tool promotes independent learning by enabling students to self-correct and receive immediate feedback. Quantitative findings support these outcomes, with 36.7% of teachers strongly agreeing that it enhanced fluency, confidence, and language skills. The chapter situates these findings within the broader post-COVID shift toward digital platforms like Microsoft Teams, emphasizing the tool's relevance in Saudi classrooms. Ghrzan highlights the potential for scaling such digital tools through national reading initiatives, especially in underserved regions, provided local authorities support infrastructure development and teacher training. The chapter ultimately presents *Reading Progress* as a valuable component of technology-enhanced language instruction, fostering multisensory engagement and supporting learner-centered pedagogy.

While the study highlights improvements in reading, speaking, listening, self-confidence, and learner independence, it lacks detail on

how these outcomes were achieved. Concepts like autonomy and self-confidence are mentioned but not clearly defined or illustrated with classroom examples. Relying primarily on teacher perceptions, the study omits qualitative evidence and student perspectives, limiting its explanatory depth. Including learner voice and classroom observations would have strengthened its pedagogical relevance, particularly in demonstrating how *Reading Progress* fosters engagement and independence.

In Chapter 5, Chahra Beloufa's case study at the Arab Open University explores the effectiveness of flipped learning within hybrid language instruction. Using a mixed-methods approach-surveys, interviews, observations, and recorded lesson analysis-the study assesses student engagement, learning outcomes, and instructional challenges among 60 students in the Faculty of Language Studies. The findings show that while student preferences varied-30% favored face-to-face learning, 27.5% online, and 17.5% a mix-hybrid models are gaining acceptance. The flipped classroom approach, in particular, was found to foster active learning and learner autonomy by shifting content delivery outside the classroom and using in-class time for interactive application. However, persistent challenges were noted. Disengagement in online settings affected 45% of students, with limited interaction and passive participation remaining key barriers. Cultural factors-such as reluctance to use cameras, especially among female students-also impacted engagement. The study emphasizes the need for curriculum redesign that integrates asynchronous tools, promotes in-class collaboration, and aligns with Saudi universities' digital transformation goals.

Although the study claims a mixed-methods design, it relies predominantly on quantitative data, offering minimal integration of interview findings. This limits its capacity to capture student perspectives on engagement, autonomy, and cultural dynamics-crucial for understanding hybrid learning in the Saudi context. While the chapter proposes useful strategies for promoting active learning, such as inquiry-based tasks and interactive materials, these remain decontextualized due to the absence of qualitative insights. In a setting shaped by factors like camera use and gender norms, excluding student voices weakens the study's learner-centered orientation. Additionally, the discussion of challenges-passive engagement, low self-regulation, and isolation-further underscores the importance of student agency and voice. Without a deeper exploration of how learners navigate these issues, the study falls short of offering a truly learner-centered perspective on technology-mediated education.

In Chapter 6, Talal Daweli investigates virtual instruction in second language (L2) academic writing at a Saudi university during the COVID-19 pandemic. This descriptive, practitioner-focused case study explores how instructors design writing tasks and the challenges they face in virtual settings. Data were gathered through classroom observations, instructional materials, student writing samples, and email interviews with three experienced EFL instructors.

The findings reveal that writing tasks were often formulaic and lacked real-world relevance. Instruction emphasized form over meaning, reflecting broader concerns in L2 pedagogy about the neglect of communicative and expressive skills. Instructors also cited challenges such as low student engagement, limited peer interaction, and inadequate technical support. Daweli calls for improved technological infrastructure and more synchronous peer collaboration to foster a stronger sense of community. The chapter underscores that effective virtual instruction-especially for skills-based courses like academic writing-requires both robust technical support and sound pedagogy.

Although the study addresses an important gap in virtual L2 writing

research in Saudi higher education, its analysis remains surface-level. It describes instructional practices as “formulaic” and “decontextualized” but offers little insight into their causes or how to resolve them through curriculum or assessment reform. The chapter also fails to show how these practices limit learners’ communicative and expressive development or how instruction could shift toward more meaningful writing. While it recommends preparing students to use collaborative tools, it overlooks the pedagogical and institutional support instructors need—such as training, scaffolding strategies, and adequate resources. This one-sided focus places the burden on students while neglecting teacher agency and systemic challenges.

The remaining chapters explore the integration of multimedia and AI tools—such as Microsoft *Reading Progress*, flipped classrooms, movie clips, and ChatGPT—in language instruction, particularly within vocational education. Chapter 7, authored by Mohammed Dahab, underscores the pedagogical value of incorporating authentic multimedia into vocational language education. Dahab examines the use of English movie clips to enhance speaking skills among Saudi vocational students. Grounded in Krashen’s Monitor Theory and Communicative Language Teaching (CLT), the study adopts a mixed-methods design involving a questionnaire with 35 students and interviews with 4 English teachers. Findings reveal strong student motivation to learn English for communication and improve speaking skills, alongside dissatisfaction with traditional methods. In contrast, 81% of students reported significant improvement in vocabulary, fluency, and pronunciation through movie clips. Subtitles were widely seen as beneficial, while translated versions were less effective. Teachers echoed these sentiments, citing increased motivation, reduced anxiety, and authentic language exposure. This chapter calls for reimagining curriculum materials to include student-centered, contextually rich tools—such as film-based activities—that support oral proficiency and align with learners’ professional communication needs.

While the study offers useful insights into using movie clips in vocational language instruction, its methodological limitations weaken its impact. The small qualitative sample—limited to 4 teacher interviews—and reliance on structured student questionnaires restrict the depth and diversity of perspectives. Without qualitative student input, the study lacks a nuanced, learner-centered understanding of how audiovisual materials affect language development, motivation, and confidence. Although framed as mixed-methods, the study places greater emphasis on quantitative data, which somewhat limits the integration of qualitative insights—particularly from students—and may reduce the interpretive depth typically expected from a mixed-methods design.

Chapter 8 focuses on language learning technologies in Saudi Arabia. The authors provide a broad review of the technological tools used in Saudi language classrooms over the past decade. The chapter categorizes tools by type (e.g., mobile apps, online games, LMS platforms) and discusses their effectiveness in skill development and assessment. The authors caution, however, that digital tools must be integrated with clear pedagogical goals and adequate training. For Saudi policymakers and school leaders, this chapter recommends investing in teacher training programs that blend technological fluency with evidence-based language teaching practices.

The final chapter offers a forward-looking exploration of how AI—specifically ChatGPT—is reshaping language education. The authors highlight its potential to enhance engagement, personalize learning, support self-directed study, and automate tasks such as feedback and assessment. These features position ChatGPT as a tool for creating adaptive, interactive, and student-centered learning experiences. Crucially, the chapter balances optimism with caution. While

emphasizing ChatGPT’s affordances, it also addresses concerns around assessment integrity, equitable access, and ethical use. The authors underscore the importance of human oversight, particularly in maintaining empathy, scaffolding, and critical thinking—elements AI cannot replicate. Beyond practical applications, the chapter critiques traditional educational paradigms, arguing that AI tools remove longstanding barriers and demand a reimagining of teaching and learning. The public release of ChatGPT on November 30, 2022, is framed as a pivotal moment in educational history. The authors call on language educators and researchers to proactively engage with AI, not as a threat, but as an opportunity to transform language teaching in line with a rapidly evolving digital landscape. While AI’s potential is immense, its long-term impact remains underexplored within the Saudi educational context. It is therefore premature to fully position tools like ChatGPT as opportunities without grounding their use in robust empirical evidence. At this stage, key questions around equitable access, teacher readiness, and the critical integration of AI into curricula remain unanswered. As such, its release is the beginning of a potential paradigm shift, but whose trajectory is still uncertain and demands sustained, critical investigation.

3. A critical Discussion of the Book

In evaluating *Language Education in Saudi Arabia: Integrating Technology in the Classroom*, this section outlines the volume’s key strengths, highlights its core thematic contributions, and critically examines its limitations. While each chapter is analyzed individually, this review also considers the edited volume as a cohesive whole. The editors’ thematic organization allows for certain gaps in one chapter to be addressed in others. Together, these elements provide a balanced assessment of the book’s relevance for researchers, educators, and policymakers navigating the evolving landscape of English language education in Saudi Arabia. The volume brings together a diverse range of contributions—including corpus analyses, case studies, systematic reviews, and practitioner reflections—that effectively document the pedagogical, technological, and cultural shifts aligned with the goals of Vision 2030. By showcasing classroom-based applications and critically engaging with tools such as ChatGPT, flipped learning models, and virtual writing platforms, the volume offers both a snapshot of current practices and a forward-looking vision for digitally mediated language instruction. The introduction clearly establishes the book’s central themes—learner corpora, data-driven learning (DDL), and artificial intelligence—while the conclusion reinforces these insights by emphasizing the ongoing shift toward personalized, technology-supported teaching and learning in Saudi classrooms. Each chapter is well-structured, with clearly defined sections covering objectives, methodology, findings, and implications. One of the volume’s core strengths lies in its documentation of context-sensitive practices, promoting a paradigm shift—from viewing technology as a supplementary aid to embracing it as an embedded, adaptive component of language education in Saudi classrooms. Second, the content is rich and diverse, spanning educational levels (elementary to university), learning contexts (vocational, hybrid, and online), and tools (corpora, apps, multimedia, AI). Case studies such as the use of “Reading Progress” in Najran or flipped classrooms at the Arab Open University offer valuable localized insights into how digital tools function within specific institutional and sociocultural constraints. These real-world applications add credibility and ground the book in lived educational experience.

A closer analysis of the volume’s theoretical grounding, content scope, and presentation reveals both strengths and notable limitations. While the title *Language Education in Saudi Arabia: Integrating Technology in the Classroom* suggests a broad, nationwide perspective, most chapters

are based on case studies from urban, higher education institutions. Only a few chapters—such as Chapter 4 on elementary education in Najran and Chapter 7 on vocational training—explore less typical contexts, but these remain exceptions. Key sectors like public K–12 schools, rural areas, private institutions, and teacher training programs receive minimal attention. While chapters on corpus-based learning, flipped classrooms, and AI tools like ChatGPT showcase how technology can enhance language skills, their applicability is limited in less-resourced or K–12 settings. Thus, the book's empirical scope appears somewhat limited in breadth. Chapter 4 cannot represent the complexity of Saudi Arabia's diverse school system, especially in rural or under-resourced areas. Similarly, sectors such as private education, teacher training colleges, and adult literacy programs are largely absent. This limits the book's ability to reflect the full sociolinguistic and infrastructural diversity of Saudi education.

Additionally, the volume also centers almost exclusively on English language instruction, overlooking the role of Arabic for non-native residents and the multilingual realities of many classrooms. The exclusive focus on English language education overlooks the role of Arabic and the experiences of multilingual learners. In a context where Arabic is both the dominant language and a primary medium of instruction—and where linguistic diversity is increasingly present—this focus offers an opportunity to further explore how technology could be leveraged to support Arabic literacy, translanguaging practices, and the preservation of heritage languages. A more inclusive, regionally diverse, and critically engaged approach—especially regarding linguistic diversity and language policy—would have significantly strengthened the volume's contribution.

The editors introduce the volume as addressing both teaching and learning within the context of Vision 2030 and digital transformation. While teachers' experiences and classroom practices are central, the emotional, motivational, and cognitive responses of students to these technologies are rarely explored. In parallel, Saudi Arabia's educational landscape has undergone significant transformation, with a growing emphasis on enhancing student engagement—underscoring the importance of adopting student-centered approaches in this evolving context (Alqahtani and Alhamami, 2024; Al Sultan et al., 2025). Nevertheless, a critical analysis of most chapters reveals a continued focus on teaching—highlighting classroom practices, teacher perceptions, and instructional tools—while learner perspectives remain largely overlooked. Although several studies in this volume cite low engagement as a challenge and propose tech-based solutions, few examine how students navigate their roles or reflect on their learning identities. Moreover, while instructional uses of digital tools are well covered, the volume offers little critique of how assessment aligns with communicative and autonomous learning goals. For example, chapters like 4 and 7 touch on student engagement and motivation, but students' voices and emotional experiences remain secondary. Although Chapters 2 and 3 emphasize the value of corpus-based research for both language analysis and teacher training, they miss a crucial opportunity to reflect on the pedagogical implications of their own findings—particularly the limited use of self-mention and attitude markers. These features are closely tied to student identity and learner autonomy and deserve more attention within teacher education frameworks aimed at developing critical writing skills in EFL contexts.

While the book claims to balance theory and practice, the depth of theoretical engagement varies across chapters. Chapters on corpus linguistics (1–3) and AI applications (9) demonstrate strong theoretical grounding, drawing on frameworks like Hyland's stance and engagement model, DDL, and sociocognitive perspectives. While DDL is a promising avenue for promoting learner autonomy in Saudi classrooms, the volume does not fully capitalize on this potential.

These chapters offer clear research rationales and situate findings within broader linguistic theory.

In contrast, chapters on multimedia tools and flipped classrooms lean toward practical applications with limited theoretical depth. Some case studies lack methodological transparency or present shallow data analysis, reducing their generalizability and scholarly rigor. Although several studies claim mixed-method approaches, many rely heavily on quantitative data (e.g., Chapters 5 and 7), underrepresenting learners' lived experiences. Evidence interpretation tends to be descriptive rather than analytical, often highlighting positive outcomes without addressing limitations or contextual factors. The absence of student perspectives further contributes to an instructor-centric narrative, overlooking key dimensions of learner engagement, autonomy, and self-regulation. This gap is especially notable given the pedagogical focus of the volume and leaves unresolved how virtual environments affect the development of independent, self-regulated writers. In Chapter 6, findings highlight a missed opportunity to cultivate learner agency and communicative competence—skills that are essential in both language learning and digital-age pedagogy. When writing instruction prioritizes form over meaning, it often marginalizes learners' perspectives, limiting their ability to engage authentically with language. Such practices underscore the need to center the learner experience—not merely as passive recipients of instruction, but as active participants whose voices and identities shape the learning process.

While the volume presents AI as a forward-looking theme, it includes only one chapter on the topic. Chapter 9 offers a strong introduction to ChatGPT's pedagogical potential in university classrooms and is rightly framed as part of the shift toward personalized, flexible learning. However, it lacks critical engagement with ethical implications, algorithmic bias, and broader integration across K–12 education or teacher training. The editors do not position this chapter as the start of a sustained inquiry into AI, nor do they offer a roadmap for its long-term role in Saudi education. As a result, AI appears more as an emerging topic than a fully developed research focus. The inclusion is timely and commendable, but it falls short of establishing a comprehensive or critical foundation, leaving room for future work to address AI's wider pedagogical, ethical, and sociocultural implications. Additionally, while the volume presents AI as a forward-looking area, it includes only one chapter on the topic. Chapter 9 provides an excellent introduction to ChatGPT's pedagogical potential but does not sufficiently explore AI's ethical implications, algorithmic bias, or its integration across other educational levels. The editors do not clearly frame this chapter as the beginning of a broader conversation, leaving readers with an emerging theme rather than a developed research agenda.

4. Conclusion and Future Recommendations

The editors present the volume as globally relevant, offering a glimpse into the future of language learning. Yet, its true value lies in what it calls for—highlighting gaps that future research must address. In this sense, it serves as a roadmap for further inquiry, offering practical insights for language educators in Saudi Arabia and beyond. A consistent message emerges: technology's potential can only be realized with adequate teacher support, critical reflection, and contextual awareness. Additionally, increasing emphasis on integrating technology and AI, advancements tend to prioritize tools over pedagogical perspectives. As a result, this volume remains largely within teacher-centered perspectives with limited data on students' perceptions and experiences with language learning, technology, data-driven learning (DDL), and AI.

Looking ahead, future research in Saudi language education should

address several key areas. Longitudinal studies are needed to examine the sustained impact of AI and digital tools on learner autonomy, motivation, and proficiency. Equally important is investigating effective teacher training models that equip educators to critically and creatively integrate technology into pedagogy. Research must also explore sociocultural and ethical concerns, including digital equity, cultural representation, and learners' emotional responses to AI. Interdisciplinary collaboration across applied linguistics, instructional design, computer science, and sociolinguistics could foster the development of context-sensitive, culturally grounded AI tools.

A more balanced focus in future research would offer a fuller understanding of how both teachers and students experience this technological shift. A more learner-centered focus is essential, particularly in exploring how students cognitively and emotionally navigate tech-mediated environments across different regions, languages, and socioeconomic backgrounds. While language instruction remains largely form-focused and often disconnected from meaningful, contextually relevant use, further research is needed to explore how shifting toward student-centered approaches might enhance learners' expressive and communicative development and, in turn, influence their engagement with and use of AI and digital tools. Future research should also investigate how teachers can effectively customize instruction to accommodate diverse learner needs across different contexts, with particular attention to student voice, cultural relevance, and the integration of adaptive technologies (Sigalla and Kimario, 2025). Future work should also advance corpus-based pedagogy by promoting DDL strategies that support all four language skills and develop students' rhetorical awareness and academic voice. Rather than using corpora solely for assessment, DDL can empower learners to engage with authentic texts and co-construct meaning.

In conclusion, *Language Education in Saudi Arabia: Integrating Technology in the Classroom* offers a timely portrait of a country in transition, where educators are navigating both the promises and challenges of educational technology. While the volume could benefit from broader coverage and deeper theoretical and learner engagement, it provides a solid foundation for future research and practice. It invites educators, policymakers, and researchers to critically engage with the digital tools shaping the future of language education in Saudi Arabia.

Data Availability Statement

The data that support the findings of this study are available on request from the corresponding author.

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Conflicts of Interest

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Biographies

Hajar Khalifa Al Sultan

Department of English Language, College of Arts, King Faisal University, Al Ahsa, Saudi Arabia, 00966503967855, hkalsultan@kfu.edu.sa

Dr. Al Sultan is an Assistant Professor of Language, Culture, and ESL/EFL Education at King Faisal University. She specializes in qualitative research and discursive analysis, with a focus on language, culture, perceptions, and social interaction across educational, intellectual, legal, and healthcare contexts. She is currently teaching in the Department of English Language. She has published in Scopus-indexed Q1 and Q2 journals. She has a strong academic background, diverse professional experiences, and a clear commitment to interdisciplinary research and community engagement.

ORCID: 0000-0002-2176-6836

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